

iPhones for rent: full experience without the full price

Owning the latest iPhone can be an expensive prospect. For some, renting is the way to go.

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The concept of renting things that are too expensive to purchase is nothing new. In ancient Rome, for instance, plebeians rented living spaces from patricians-wealthy landowners. Modern times find gamers renting gaming consoles by the hour for that much-needed respite.

These days, however, people rent iPhones, one of the most advanced, fashionable — yet expensive — smartphone brands. There are arguably many reasons, from trying to appear as a certain social class, or simply to have access to what many believe is the best smartphone camera.

Edgar Bayu Refansyah, 23, a sociology tutor and postgraduate student at the Faculty of Sociology of Universitas Indonesia, pointed out two sides of the coin when it comes to the iPhone rentals phenomenon.

"The iPhone can be seen as a tool to boost the quality and productivity of certain tasks, knowing the brand's capability to facilitate such a thing. Moreover, the iPhone is known for its camera quality. The iPhone rental business can be an alternative for photographers or content creators to produce quality visual content at an affordable price," Edgar said.

"[However], we know a lot of people in our society who believe that owning an iPhone equals having an opulent lifestyle. Some use the gadget for the sake of social acknowledgment, and those who rent an iPhone for [imitating] a mere lifestyle usually look for a pseudo-satisfaction that will not last long."

All the different reasons

While it might be true that some people use the service only for "lifestyle" reasons, some others rent an iPhone for more practical reasons. Other than the affordable price, renting is preferred when it is only needed for a limited period.

Take Mila Harlind for example. The 23-year-old East Jakarta resident is an iPhone rental customer who uses the service to help her with some tasks.

"When I was in college, I needed an iPhone XR to help me with data transfer and backup. This iPhone rental helps me because I find it easy to use the items I need when I don't have them myself. "I don't need to buy it because I can just rent it," Mila said.

It was 2021 when Mila found information about iPhone rentals, stumbling upon a rental business named Byebeli, which is owned by Jeffry, who prefers to only share his nickname for privacy reasons.

The 30-year-old started the enterprise in 2016 and said that most of his customers are mostly college students or recent graduates who need an iPhone for many different reasons.

"Some of them rent an iPhone as a backup phone because their phone is broken or in repair," Jeffry explained. "Some others even rent an iPhone for an online mobile game tournament where they need a compatible device to play the game."

A promising but double-edged business opportunity

Jeffry's rental business started when he was in Bali and purchased a GoPro to capture some moments while surfing and snorkeling.

"However, because I work during the weekdays, I was unable to use the GoPro frequently. That's when the idea of renting the GoPro came to me," he explained.

From GoPro, Jeffry expanded his business and offered different items for rent, including an iPhone. Today, Byebeli provides varying types of iPhones with a rental fee ranging from Rp100,000 to 400,000 (US\$6.74 to 26.97) per day. When asked whether people would also ask for an Android for the same purpose, Jeffry said that customers typically look for an iPhone instead.

"I realized that it could be beneficial for others too, where a lot of people can still experience the product that they need, but at a more affordable price," Jeffry said.

The business also offers various promotions to attract more customers and has expanded to several areas in Jabodetabek, Bandung, Yogyakarta, Surabaya, Malang, as well as Bali. The range of promotions has been successful in drawing

new and keeping existing customers alike, regardless of their underlying need or motivation in renting the phone.

"I've got a promo where I only needed to pay a 10-days' worth of rental fee to rent an iPhone for a month. The iPhone is also guaranteed to be genuine and functional," Mila said.

Initially seen as one solution to handle communication problems, iPhone rentals are more common in big cities. However, it is just a matter of time before this phenomenon might also reach smaller towns and even rural areas.

"On the bright side, iPhone rent can help those who need to boost their productivity at an affordable price," said Edgar. However, according to Edgar, the iPhone has been sociologically interpreted as a luxury item – there's this symbolic interactionism that settles Apple products as a sign of proof that an owner is a financially capable person. This is where things can go wrong.

"[It will especially affect] certain groups within the community that prioritizes lifestyle rather than staple needs," Edgar said. "If the use of the iPhone is not addressed properly and wisely, the phenomenon can potentially be hazardous for society as it will increase hedonism."